

Psalms 90

Our Dwelling Place

Lord, thou hast been our dwelling place in all generations
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *LORD, thou hast been our dwelling place in all generations.*
- 2 *Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever thou hadst formed the earth and the world, even from everlasting to everlasting, thou art God.*
- 3 *Thou turnest man to destruction; and sayest, Return, ye children of men.*
- 4 *For a thousand years in thy sight are but as yesterday when it is past, and as a watch in the night.*
- 5 *Thou carriest them away as with a flood; they are as a sleep: in the morning they are like grass which groweth up.*
- 6 *In the morning it flourisheth, and groweth up; in the evening it is cut down, and withereth.*
- 7 *For we are consumed by thine anger, and by thy wrath are we troubled.*
- 8 *Thou hast set our iniquities before thee, our secret sins in the light of thy countenance.*
- 9 *For all our days are passed away in thy wrath: we spend our years as a tale that is told.*
- 10 *The days of our years are threescore years and ten; and if by reason of strength they be fourscore years, yet is their strength labour and sorrow; for it is soon cut off, and we fly away.*
- 11 *Who knoweth the power of thine anger? even according to thy fear, so is thy wrath.*
- 12 *So teach us to number our days, that we may apply our hearts unto wisdom.*
- 13 *Return, O LORD, how long? and let it repent thee concerning thy servants.*
- 14 *O satisfy us early with thy mercy; that we may rejoice and be glad all our days.*
- 15 *Make us glad according to the days wherein thou hast afflicted us, and the years wherein we have seen evil.*
- 16 *Let thy work appear unto thy servants, and thy glory unto their children.*
- 17 *And let the beauty of the LORD our God be upon us: and establish thou the work of our hands upon us; yea, the work of our hands establish thou it.*

2 · CONTEXT

The only psalm explicitly attributed to Moses, Psalm 90 opens Book IV of the Psalter with sober reflection on human mortality set against God's eternity, likely composed in view of a generation dying in the wilderness under judgment. Its famous meditation on numbering our days is not despair but wisdom—an appeal to live purposefully in light of how brief life actually is. Henry reads it as the necessary foundation for any request for mercy: honest reckoning with mortality before asking God to make the days that remain count.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens by naming God as a dwelling place across every generation, existing before the mountains were formed or the earth and world brought into being—from everlasting to everlasting, God simply is, in stark contrast to everything transient that follows.

Verse 3-6

Human life is measured against that eternity and found strikingly brief: God can return mortals to dust with a word; a thousand years are to Him like a single day, like a watch in the night. Human life is compared to a flood sweeping past, a dream, grass that flourishes in the morning and withers by evening—vivid, deliberately unflattering images of transience.

Verse 7-11

The brevity of life is tied specifically to divine judgment: consumed by God's anger, secret sins exposed in the light of His presence, years passing 'as a tale that is told.' Even a long life—seventy or, with unusual strength, eighty years—is summarized as labor and sorrow, soon over, quickly gone. The rhetorical question 'who knows the power of your anger' underscores how seriously mortality should be taken.

Verse 12-17

The psalm's turn from lament to petition: teach us to number our days, that we may gain a heart of wisdom—the entire point of dwelling on mortality is to live wisely, not to despair. The prayers that follow ask God to return, to have compassion, to satisfy with mercy so that gladness might match the days already spent in trouble, and finally to let His work and beauty be seen in and through His people, establishing the work of their hands.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Honest confrontation with the brevity of human life, set against God's changeless eternity, is meant to produce wisdom rather than despair—a deliberate, prayerful request to live the limited days one is given with purpose, gladness, and lasting significance. The psalm's movement from sober mortality to hopeful petition shows that facing death honestly is the necessary first step toward asking God to make life count.

Application for life today.

Take verse 12's prayer literally: ask God specifically to teach you to number your days so that you gain wisdom, rather than avoiding thoughts of mortality altogether. Let the psalm's honest naming of life's brevity motivate deliberate, purposeful choices now rather than indefinite postponement of what matters most. Pray verse 17's request—that God would establish the work of your hands—as a way of asking that your limited days leave something of lasting significance.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. How does honestly confronting the brevity of your own life, as this psalm does (vv. 3–10), change what you prioritize today rather than later?

2. What would it practically look like to pray verse 12—'teach me to number my days'—as a specific, recurring request rather than a poetic phrase?

3. Where do you most need God to 'establish the work of your hands' (v. 17)—to give lasting significance to effort that currently feels temporary or uncertain?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).